5. Soviet ships stop short of the U.S. quarantine line (October 25).

6. Khrushchev letter offers withdrawal of Soviet missiles in return for U.S. noninvasion pledge (October 26), followed by a second Khrushchev letter demanding U.S. withdrawal of Turkish missiles for Soviet withdrawal of Cuban missiles (October 27).

7. U.S. responds affirmatively to first Khrushchev letter but warns that if missiles are not withdrawn by Sunday, October 28, invasion or air strike will follow Monday or Tuesday (October 27).

8. Khrushchev announces withdrawal of the missiles (October 28).

Perhaps the most obvious scenario by which nuclear war might have emerged from the sequence follows the actual course of events through step seven, but then proceeds:

(8) Khrushchev reiterates that any attack on Soviet missiles and personnel in Cuba will be met with a full Soviet retaliatory response (October 28).

(9) U.S. “surgical” air strike against Soviet missiles (destroying all operational ballistic missiles and killing a limited number of Soviet personnel) (October 30).

(10) Soviet medium-range ballistic missiles attack U.S. missiles in Turkey (destroying all ballistic missiles and killing a small number of Americans) (October 31).

(11) In accord with obligations under the NATO treaty, U.S. medium-range missiles in Europe attack bases in the Soviet Union from which missiles that attacked the Turkish bases were launched (October 31).

(12) Soviet Union, fearing additional U.S. attacks on its limited number of ICBMs, attacks the U.S. (November 1).

(13) U.S. ICBMs attack the Soviet Union (November 1).

Alternative scenarios leading to nuclear war could start with the firing of Soviet missiles in Cuba or the sinking of a ship. Moreover, a large number of potential “accidents” might have triggered nuclear war, for example, the Soviet downing of a U-2 aircraft on Saturday, October 27, nearly precipitated an American attack on Soviet surface-to-air missiles. Robert Kennedy identifies at least five other incidents that could have served as a nuclear fuse.

Given the many possible nuclear dead ends that branch off the path of confrontation, why did President Kennedy start down this path? Need Soviet recklessness have been matched in kind? Could Kennedy not have accepted their missiles in Cuba and announced to the world that Russian roulette was a game he would not play? What consequences of the Soviet